



WALLIS' WELLINGTONS

Designed by Barnes Wallis, the twin-engined Vickers Wellington was the RAF's most advanced bomber at the start of the war. Hopelessly vulnerable in daylight raids, it proved a reasonably effective night bomber, taking part in raids on Germany until withdrawn from front-line service in 1943.

who had called on all combatants to refrain from using aircraft as a weapon of terror. Until May 1940, RAF bombers were restricted to attacks on naval targets and to dropping propaganda leaflets.

In any case Bomber Command was woefully ill-equipped to carry out a strategic bombing campaign. Its twin-engined Bristol Blenheim, Armstrong Whitworth Whitley, Handley Page Hampden, and Vickers Wellington bombers were inadequate in bombload, speed, and armament.

Their crews were mostly short on training and had to operate with poor bomb-sights and navigational equipment limited to a compass and a map. Yet it was presumed that they would



NAVIGATIONAL EQUIPMENT

Bomber Command's twin-engined bombers had to rely, for the most part, on maps and compasses to navigate to their targets. The map (far left) is Sheet N53, Berlin, of a British wartime series intended for both aircrews and ground troops. The astro-compass (left) used the Sun, the Moon, and other heavenly bodies to help aircrews plot accurate courses.